

Missing Middle Housing — Strategy & Draft Messaging

For: Meghan **From:** Sheri **Date:** April 30, 2026

TL;DR (60 seconds)

I've drafted the missing middle pillar for your platform. There's a strong, gentle frame that should land even in Port Moody — built around *"more homes for the people we already love."* The polished website language is in **Section 1**.

The risk: missing middle is the third-rail issue here, and the Sheri / Dawar / Port Moody Multiplex connection will eventually surface publicly. My recommendation is to **lean in** — I publicly own a "community advocate" identity before the campaign launches missing middle, so the connection isn't a discovery for opponents to make. **Section 2** has the case for that, and the alternative if you'd rather play it smaller.

Section 3 is the short list of decisions I need from you to move forward.

Reference material — strategic frame details, hard questions you'll get asked, sample commitments, sequencing — is at the back. Read it only if you want the depth.

Estimated reading time: 8 minutes for sections 1-3. Skim Section 1 and you'll have the gist in 3.

Section 1 — The Messaging

This is what would actually appear on the Platform page, as a new subsection under Pillar 01: Housing & Growth.

Headline / banner

More homes for the people we already love.

Subtitle

Missing middle housing — a thoughtful path to keep Port Moody affordable for the families, seniors, and neighbours who built it.

Body — paragraph 1

Walk through any Port Moody neighbourhood and you'll find someone with a story like this. A retired teacher who's been here 35 years, in a four-bedroom house she can no longer manage, watching her grandkids grow up in Surrey because nothing smaller is available near her. A young family priced out of buying within the city they were raised in. A widow living alone in a house with a garden she can't tend, who would love a smaller home with a suite to rent.

This is the affordability crisis, but it isn't a crisis of strangers. It's a crisis of the people we already love.

Body — paragraph 2

"Missing middle" is the kind of housing that used to fill the gap between a single-family home and an apartment building — duplexes, side-by-side townhomes, garden suites, courtyard homes, four-plexes that look like a single large house. They've been built across the Lower Mainland for over a century. Most North American cities have lost the ability to build them. Port Moody is one of those cities. Bringing them back, carefully and on lots where it makes sense, is how we give the next generation of Port Moody families a foothold here — and how we let people who built this community age in place, near the people and the places they love.

Body — paragraph 3 (your voice / approach)

The work has to be done carefully. Not every lot is the right lot. Design standards, parking, tree retention, and infrastructure capacity all matter. The goal isn't transformation. It's options — for the people who already live here, or who grew up here and want to come back.

Pull quote

"This isn't about changing what Port Moody is. It's about making sure the people who made Port Moody what it is can still afford to live here." — Meghan Lahti

(Three more pull quote options in the reference section if you'd rather pick a different one or rewrite.)

What missing middle actually looks like (visual feature)

A simple three-image grid on the page, with these captions:

A garden suite (laneway home). A small one- or two-bedroom cottage tucked behind an existing single-family home, sharing the lot. Often used for an aging parent, an adult child, or rented out to help a family afford the mortgage. Streetscape unchanged.

A side-by-side duplex. Two homes that share one wall, each with its own front door, yard, and driveway. From the street, it looks like a large single-family home — same trees, same scale. Two families call it home instead of one.

A courtyard fourplex. Four homes arranged around a small shared green space. Each has its own entrance and outdoor space. Common in older Vancouver neighbourhoods. Lower in profile than a typical apartment building, often less imposing than a McMansion.

Addressing the four concerns we'll hear most

These can live as a small FAQ on the page, or be your talking points at doors and town halls.

“This will turn our quiet street into apartment buildings.” > No. Missing middle is the opposite of apartment buildings. We’re talking about homes that look and feel like the houses already on your street — sometimes literally indistinguishable from a large single-family home. The point is to keep the streetscape, while letting more than one family live well on the same land.

“There’s no parking now. This will make it worse.” > Off-street parking requirements stay. New homes have to bring their own parking. Homes near transit are the ones we’d consider first — those residents are the most likely to use SkyTrain rather than drive.

“Our schools and sewers can’t handle more people.” > That’s why nothing happens without infrastructure first. If a neighbourhood’s capacity is at the limit, missing middle waits there until the capacity exists. Growth follows infrastructure, not the other way around.

“Real estate investors will buy up everything.” > Tools exist to limit this — owner-occupancy requirements, anti-flipping provisions, density bonuses tied to long-term ownership. We use them. Missing middle should help young families and aging seniors, not become an asset class for absentee owners.

Launch social posts (for when we’re ready)

Option A — Story-led, suited to Facebook:

Last week I had a conversation on a doorstep that I haven’t been able to stop thinking about.

A widow, 72 years old, in a four-bedroom house she’s lived in for 35 years. She wants to downsize. She wants to stay in Port Moody, near her grandkids. But there’s nothing here for her. The only options are a tower condo in Inlet Centre, or a move to Maple Ridge.

This is a Port Moody problem we’ve created and a Port Moody problem we can fix.

Over the coming weeks I’ll be talking more about “missing middle” housing — duplexes, garden suites, side-by-side townhomes, courtyard fourplexes. The kinds of homes that quietly fill the gap between a single-family house and an apartment tower. They’ve been built across the Lower Mainland for over a century. We’ve made them nearly impossible in Port Moody. I think we can change that — carefully, neighbourhood by neighbourhood, with the design standards Port Moody is known for.

More to come. I’d love to hear from you.

— Meghan

Option B — Values-led, suited to Instagram:

A Port Moody where the people who built this community can still afford to live in it. A Port Moody where seniors can downsize without leaving their neighbourhood. A Port Moody where teachers, nurses, and small-business owners can

raise families here, not commute from somewhere else. That's what missing middle housing is about. More to come.

Section 2 — The Risks Worth Knowing

Two risks. Both manageable. Worth thinking about before we publish.

Risk 1 — Political reality of densification in Port Moody

Densification is the third-rail issue in Port Moody. The residents most likely to vote are also the most resistant to change. The wording above is built to thread the needle — naming the opportunity, leading with empathy for people who can no longer afford to stay, conceding the legitimate concerns directly. But there's no version of this messaging that won't draw heat from the loudest 5% of the city.

The mitigation is what's already in Section 1: lead with seniors and growing families (sympathetic faces), use specific visual examples (concrete and small-scale), address concerns up front rather than waiting to be cornered. Don't lead the campaign launch with this — it's a Platform-page subsection, not the headline.

Risk 2 — The Sheri / Dawar / Port Moody Multiplex connection

You know Dawar's working on Port Moody Multiplex, including the conversations he's had with city staff. So this isn't news between us. The strategic question for the campaign is: how do we get ahead of that connection publicly, before opponents do?

My recommendation: lean fully in.

I publicly own a "community advocate for missing middle housing" identity across all my channels (bio, socials, email signature) before missing middle launches as a campaign pillar. Then if/when anyone draws the Sheri/Dawar/Meghan line, the public answer is already in the open: *"Sheri's been a known public advocate on this issue, her family also works in housing, and she's been transparent about all of it from day one."*

That reframes me from "developer-adjacent campaign manager" to "housing-passion advocate with a known disclosure." It also gives you a clean, ready answer-line if a journalist asks: *"My campaign manager Sheri Zada has been a public advocate on missing middle housing, separately from her family's work in housing development. She's been transparent about all of that from day one. The policy positions on my platform are mine, shaped by 30 years of Port Moody public service."*

The trade-offs of leaning in:

- It puts a small spotlight on me. Once my bio publicly identifies me as an advocate, I become a person opponents try to engage. I'll need to be ready for that.
- It doesn't fully neutralize the connection. If you win and missing middle gets implemented, opponents will still try to use it. Lean-in reduces but doesn't eliminate the attack surface.

- It commits us. Once I'm publicly an advocate, walking it back later looks worse than never going public. So this is a one-way door.

The alternative: play it smaller.

We keep missing middle as a quieter piece of the housing platform, not its own pillar. My signature loses the "advocate" line. We avoid the connection becoming a public conversation. We accept that it's a latent risk that could surface, and we have a holding response ready if it does.

This is defensible. It gives the campaign simpler optics — at the cost of a less courageous housing platform.

Section 3 — Decisions I Need From You

Six things. None of them have to be answered today, but I can't move forward on missing middle until they are.

- **1. Lean in or play it smaller?** Section 2 lays out the case for both. This decision unlocks everything else.
 - **2. What's your actual record on garden suites, laneway homes, duplex zoning, or Bill 44 implementation in Port Moody council?** I need to know before any "already delivered" or commitment language goes on the website. This is the one that determines whether the platform reads as credible or as an opportunistic flip.
 - **3. Are there specific neighbourhoods you'd publicly commit to NOT blanket-rezoning?** (Heritage Mountain, Glenayre, Pleasantide, College Park, etc.) Some campaigns find this kind of commitment helpful as reassurance.
 - **4. The pull quote in Section 1 — does it sound like you?** If not, I have three alternatives in the reference section, or rewrite freely.
 - **5. The journalist-ready answer line in Section 2 (Risk 2) — are you comfortable with that wording?** Or would you rather it be framed differently?
 - **6. Tone check — is Section 1 too soft, about right, or push harder?** I erred gentle. You know the room better than I do.
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That's all you need to read to move forward. Everything below is reference material — only there if you want depth on a particular question.

Reference

A. How to position this on the website (3 options)

Option A — One bullet under the existing "Housing & Growth" pillar. Lowest profile, lowest risk, lowest courage. Easy to dismiss as not a real priority.

Option B — A standalone “Missing Middle” subsection within the Housing pillar, with its own section on the Platform page. Recommended. What I drafted above. Lets you signal real leadership without making it the front-and-centre headline. Distinguishes it from the big-development conversation (PCI, Coronation Park, Portwood) which is a different debate.

Option C — Make missing middle the lead message of the campaign. Highest courage, highest political risk in Port Moody. Probably wrong for this election unless polling shows the city has shifted dramatically.

B. Alternative pull quotes

If the one in Section 1 doesn’t feel like you, pick from these or rewrite freely.

“The goal isn’t to change what Port Moody is. It’s to make sure the people who built it can still afford to live in it.”

“Missing middle is how my generation’s parents got to keep living near their grandkids. We’ve made that nearly impossible. We can fix that — carefully.”

“This isn’t about more housing. It’s about different housing — homes that match how families actually live in 2026.”

C. Hard questions you’ll be asked (rehearse before any launch)

1. *“Have you ever voted to upzone a single-family neighbourhood in Port Moody?”* — what’s your real record? This is the question that determines campaign credibility.
2. *“Will you commit to never blanket-rezoning Heritage Mountain / Glenayre / [neighbourhood]?”* — what’s the right answer for you?
3. *“What’s your position on the BC government’s Bill 44 mandate?”* — defend it, push back on it, or thread the needle?
4. *“Will multiplex housing have to look the same as the existing homes on the street?”* — design control specifics.
5. *“How is this different from what your opponent is saying?”* — what’s the contrast?
6. *“Who benefits financially from this?”* — be ready for this directly. (This is where the disclosure conversation matters most.)

D. Sample commitments (draft — yours to rewrite)

For the website, under Meghan’s Commitments. **These should reflect what you’ve actually voted for and are willing to defend.** Rewrite or replace freely.

- **Carefully, neighbourhood by neighbourhood.** Missing middle introduced where lot size, infrastructure, and street design support it — not as a blanket rezoning.
- **Strong design standards.** Setbacks, height limits, and design guidelines that protect the streetscape, the trees, and the character that makes Port Moody Port Moody.
- **Infrastructure first.** No upzoning without confirming sewage, water, traffic, and school capacity can handle what’s added. Where capacity is short, growth waits.

- **Owner-occupier focus where possible.** Tools to favour homeowners over speculative investors — owner-occupancy requirements, bonuses for genuine multigenerational use, anti-flipping provisions.
- **Tree retention enforced.** Existing tree-protection bylaws strengthened, not weakened, as part of any missing-middle approval.
- **The province's mandate, shaped on our terms.** Bill 44 requires every BC municipality to allow small-scale multi-unit housing. Port Moody complies — *thoughtfully, on a Port Moody timeline, with Port Moody design.*

E. Sequencing if we go ahead

1. You decide: lean in, or play it smaller. (Decision #1 in Section 3.)
2. You take Section 1 and rewrite the commitments and pull quote in your voice.
3. We test the wording on three trusted people who aren't on the campaign — a senior, a young parent, someone from a culturally diverse community. Not for permission, just for tone.
4. (Lean-in only.) I update my bios and start posting before any campaign launch on this pillar.
5. We publish missing middle as a Platform-page subsection — not the campaign headline.
6. Don't lead the campaign announcement with this. Lead with the broader vision. Missing middle is one piece.
7. At the first town hall, this is your second-most-rehearsed topic (after Rocky Point Park). Have answers to all the hard questions on lock.

That's everything. Mark this up however works for you — Google Doc Suggesting mode, a quick voice-memo, a 30-min call. Whatever's easiest.

— Sheri